

Building Better Advisory Groups

How to make a consumer advisory group worth everyone's time, including the members'.

A consumer advisory group is one of the most common ways organisations bring in lived experience, and one of the easiest to get wrong. These are the choices that separate a group that shapes decisions from one that meets, is thanked, and is ignored.

Be clear what it is for

A group with no defined purpose becomes a standing meeting in search of one. Decide what decisions it exists to influence, tell members plainly, and revisit the purpose if it drifts.

Compose it with intent

Recruit for the range of experience the work needs, not the people easiest to find. Notice who is missing. A group that all sees the world the same way will confirm your assumptions rather than test them.

Give it real work

Advisory groups disengage when the questions are cosmetic. Bring them genuine decisions, early enough to change, and show the trail from what they said to what you did.

Set it up to succeed

Chair it well, share papers in plain language and in good time, and pay members properly. Small signals of respect decide whether people bring their whole thinking or quietly withdraw it.

Close the loop, every time

Report back what changed as a result of the group's input, including where you chose a different path and why. Nothing sustains a group like seeing its fingerprints on a decision.

Refresh it

Terms that never end curdle into habit. Rotate membership, bring in new experience, and thank people well when they leave. Continuity matters, and so does fresh air.

